

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Marketing English

Conversation lab

Use these role cards to practice a response, handle a follow-up, and repeat with a new communication challenge.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For brand, product marketing, growth, content, SEO, lifecycle, demand generation, marketing operations, social, and agency teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

How to use the conversation lab

1. Read the shared case. Spend two minutes noting the facts and your first response.
2. Assign roles. The responding professional uses role A; the listener uses role B. Read your own role privately before you begin.
3. Speak for 45-60 seconds. The listener asks a follow-up instead of simply agreeing. Continue until the meaning and next action are clear.
4. Reveal the model response. Identify one useful expression and compare it with your own wording.
5. Switch roles. Use the second-round challenge and speak again with fewer notes.

If you are studying alone

Speak both roles aloud. Leave a pause after the question, then answer without looking at the model. You can also write a four-turn exchange and read it back for clarity.

Useful conversation repair

- Could you say that another way?
- When you say that, which part do you mean?
- Let me check that I understood correctly.
- I need a moment to separate what is confirmed from what is still unknown.

Feedback

Judge whether the listener understands the situation and can identify the next action or unresolved question. Correct one meaning issue and one useful language pattern, then repeat.

CONVERSATION 01

Marketing Strategy: Audience, Insight, Problem, Outcome

SHARED CASE

A campaign brief targets "everyone who works in an office." The product is a scheduling tool, but the buyer and daily user may differ.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Who decides to buy the tool, and who uses it each day? Let's define a specific audience and the problem we are solving before choosing the campaign message.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 02

Positioning, Messaging, Brand Voice, and Proof

SHARED CASE

A draft advertisement says "the fastest tool on the market." The only evidence is an internal test against one earlier version.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The test supports a comparison with our earlier version, not the whole market. Could we use a narrower claim that accurately describes what we measured and send it for review?

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 03

Campaign Briefs, GTM Planning, and Cross-Functional Alignment

SHARED CASE

A launch brief has a date and channel list but no audience, approved message, or measure of success.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you add the primary audience, approved message, and success measure before Thursday's review? Those details will help the content and channel teams work toward the same outcome.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 04

Content, SEO, Thought Leadership, and Editorial Judgment

SHARED CASE

A proposed article targets a popular keyword, but searchers appear to want instructions while the draft is a product announcement.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The search intent appears to be instructional. Our draft announces a product instead. We could create a useful how-to article and include the product only where it helps answer the question.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 05

Paid Media, Performance Marketing, and Attribution

SHARED CASE

Paid conversions rose after a campaign change, but a discount began in the same week. A slide credits the campaign with the entire increase.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

Conversions rose after the campaign change, but the discount is another possible influence. I'll describe the timing accurately and avoid claiming that the campaign caused the entire increase.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 06

Lifecycle, CRM, Email, Marketing Ops, and Sales Handoff

SHARED CASE

A lead list is ready for sales. It contains contact details but no explanation of which contacts requested a conversation.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

The handoff needs the agreed qualification fields and contact permissions. I'll distinguish conversation requests from other activity so sales can choose an appropriate follow-up under our process.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 07

Analytics, Experimentation, Funnel Reporting, and Executive Readouts

SHARED CASE

An email experiment records 120 clicks from 2,000 delivered messages in version A and 140 from 2,000 in version B. No significance analysis is complete.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The observed click rates are 6% and 7%. Version B is higher in this sample, but we have not established whether the difference is reliable. Let's complete the planned analysis before naming a winner.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

CONVERSATION 08

Compliance, Privacy, Claims, Influencers, Brand Safety, and Crisis Response

SHARED CASE

A scheduled post includes a claim that reviewers have asked to revise. The post has not yet been published.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

The scheduled wording differs from the reviewed claim. I'll pause publication through our process and send the revised copy for approval. Please confirm which version should replace it.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.